

Using the Differentiated Student Handouts

A Guide to Self-Selection and Flexible Differentiation

What's Included

Each Mini Museum lesson plan includes **three color-coded student handouts** at different challenge levels. Students choose which level they want to work on based on how they feel about the topic—not based on a permanent ability label.



Green Level

"I want more support"

Simplified vocabulary, more scaffolding, visual aids



Yellow Level

"I'm ready for a challenge"

Grade-level appropriate, independent work



Red Level

"I want to go deeper"

Extension activities, open-ended challenges

How to Use These Handouts

1. **Print the levels you need.** You can print all three or just the ones you anticipate using.
2. **Display with color-coded labels.** Set out stacks with clear signs or place in color-coded folders.
3. **Let students choose.** Emphasize: "This is about challenge preference TODAY, not about how smart you are."
4. **Normalize switching.** If a student wants a different challenge, let them switch. This builds metacognition.
5. **No justification required.** Students don't have to explain why they chose their level.

What Each Handout Includes

All three levels cover the same core concepts but adjust complexity of vocabulary, amount of scaffolding, depth of analysis required, and independence expected.

All three levels include: Connection to exhibition artifacts, take-home element for parent engagement, reflection questions, and can be completed in class OR at home.

Language Matters

Say this: "Choose the challenge level that feels right for you today." • "Green gives more support. Yellow is grade-level. Red goes deeper. All three are good choices." • "You can switch levels anytime."

Avoid: "Green is for struggling students." • "Red is for advanced students." • "Why did you pick that level?"

Why Self-Selection Works

- ✓ **Removes stigma:** No public ability grouping. Students aren't labeled "low" or "high."
- ✓ **Builds agency:** Students develop self-awareness about when they need support vs. challenge.
- ✓ **Allows flexibility:** A student might choose Green for science (unfamiliar) and Red for ELA (confident).
- ✓ **Differentiates without labeling:** You're meeting diverse needs without fixed groups.
- ✓ **Respects daily variation:** Students might choose differently on Monday (tired) vs. Thursday (energized).

Adapting for Your Classroom

If you prefer teacher assignment: You can still use these handouts by assigning specific levels to specific students based on your knowledge of their needs. The materials work both ways.

If you want to modify: All handouts are provided as editable documents so you can customize for your specific class.

If you only want one level: That's fine too! Use whichever level best matches your class.

What the Research Says

Student self-selection of challenge level (sometimes called "differentiation by choice") has been shown to increase student motivation and engagement, develop metacognitive skills, reduce anxiety around differentiation, build growth mindset, and allow teachers to differentiate without public tracking.

The Goal: Every student engages with the core content at a level that challenges them appropriately. Some need more support to access the content. Some need extensions to stay engaged. Most are ready for grade-level work. All deserve choice and respect.

Questions?

These handouts are designed to make differentiation *easier* for you, not harder. If something isn't working, adjust it. The structure is a tool, not a rule.

Most importantly: **The handouts are optional.** The lesson plan itself provides everything you need. The handouts are an additional resource for extending learning, providing practice, or sending work home.